

has attended every G20 summit since he became president in 2013 except in Rome where he could not make it because of a resurgence of the Covid pandemic in his country. Xi not coming to Delhi, though, signalled a new low in India-China bilateral ties. It was also meant to take some of the sheen off India's G20 tenure. That was evident even during the meetings of the G20 working groups, with China emerging as the most vociferous objector, including on such petty issues as inserting the Sanskrit phrase '*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*' (the world is one family) in official communiques, saying they would rather that standard UN text was used.

Just a month and a half before the Delhi summit, there had been some signs of forward movement when National Security Advisor Ajit Doval met China's special representative Wang Yi for the BRICS NSA event in Johannesburg on July 24. Soon after, on August 7, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar confirmed that the two countries were in conversation on the border issue and had made progress in four of the six areas where the situation had been tense. He was hopeful that the remaining two in the Depsang and Demchok areas of Ladakh would be resolved soon too. On August 13-14, in the 19th round of India-China Corps Commander-level talks in Ladakh, the two sides agreed to "resolve the issue in an expeditious manner" and continue engaging in negotiations "through both military and diplomatic channels". Yet when Modi and Xi met on the sidelines of the BRICS summit on August 23, any hope of rapprochement receded when a needless controversy broke out over who had sought the meeting, with India claiming China had asked for it and Beijing refuting the assertion. A week later, China made matters worse by officially releasing the 2023 edition of its "standard map" that showed Arunachal Pradesh as part of its territory besides older claims on Aksai Chin, which Jaishankar dismissed as "absurd".

TO MODI'S CREDIT, HE REFUSED TO MAKE ANY COMPROMISE OR CONCESSIONS TO GET XI TO ATTEND THE DELHI SUMMIT

To Modi's credit, he refused to make any compromise or concession on the border issue to get Xi to attend. China